Attempts at Integrating Princely States

As mentioned earlier, the princely states were fragmented administrative pockets and the subject of integration of princely states in the phase preceding Indian independence has a long history even before the Colonial invasion. Many dynasties attempted to integrate the princely states starting from the Maghadan Kings, Bimbisara, and Ajatasatru during Mauryans, Ashoka, Chandragupta and his son Samudragupta, all of them who almost managed to bring many smaller kingdoms together, but consolidating under one rule still remained a far cry. However, when the thirst for power, jealousy and frequent disagreements among kingdoms led to resentment and disunity, it paved way for Arab and Persian invasion, establishing the Moghul empire and eventually conquering the northern part of pre-independent India.

Princely States under British Raj

a) Gun Salute System:

Therefore, by the time European colonisation, i.e. the British, Portuguese, and French, started to take over, the disunity worked in their favour to establish their presence, initially through trade. Among the three, the British managed to institute sovereignty under the crown of many princely states but not all. There were 565 princely states in pre-independent India and, the 'gun salute' system under the British rule was an open gesture to announce the level of affiliation of a princely state to the British East India Company. Therefore, there were two kinds of princely states: 'Salute Princely States' and 'Non- Salute Princely States'.

b) Salute States

The 'Salute States' were States that had the British East India presence, and there were around 117 to 120 salute states. So, the heads, rulers, or princes of these states, were greeted with gun salutes. The number of guns used to salute a particular head of a State reflected the level of honour and prestige granted to a ruler. A 21-gun salute was the highest honour granted to a ruler and rulers of lesser ranks received a minimum of 9-gun salute. Some of the rulers who received the 21-gun salute include:

- His Highness the Maharaja Scindia of Gwalior
- His Highness the Maharaja Gaekwar of Baroda
- His Highness the Maharaja of Jammu and Kashmir
- His Highness the Maharaja of Mysore
- His Exalted Highness the Nizam of Hyderabad and Berar

Some of the rulers who received 9-gun salutes include:

- The Nawab of Sachin
- The Maharaja of Patna
- The Maharana of Wadhwan
- The Nawab of Loharu

c) Non-salute States

Among the 565 Princely States, only 117 to 120 were salute states, which implied there were many other States which were under the British rule or British Raj were non-salute states. The reasons include:

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